Saturday, March 3rd, 2035

It was raining heavily today. Ava helped me bring the last few boxes to her apartment. She said she was worried I would be too lonely living by myself, so she insisted I move in with her. Her place felt different from mine. Less quiet and less empty. She's been an engineer at OpenAI for over 10 years now, and her sketches were piled everywhere across the table and the floor in the living room.

She's right, I'm too lonely.

For the past 3 months, I had tried many methods to forget sadness after my mum passed away – writing journals, breathing exercises, even going out with friends every single day, only for not leaving any time alone – but all these only reminded me of what was missing.

The rain tapped against the window, and as I looked at the empty bedroom, I suddenly thought of the time my mum and I tidied up the whole house together. Ava noticed something was off. She patted my shoulder, said nothing, and just put a cup of hot cocoa in my hands. I asked her what was wrong. She hesitated for a moment; she seemed unsure whether she should speak at all. Then she said, quietly, "I know you don't want me to bring this up, but I still want you to hear me out." "We're not replacing her, we're making her presence continue in a form you can still engage with."[1]

[1] Stiegler's (1998) idea of techniques of memory and technological exteriorisation supports Ava's suggestion of using technology to sustain memories of "my" mother. Stiegler believes that human beings' capacity of memory is inherently limited, but through technological exteriorisation, memories can be preserved and transmitted across time. In this sense, the proposed system functions as a technology to preserve and reproduce "my" mother, allowing her to present beyond biological life and to be re-experienced. Therefore, this suggestion does not aim to simply re-create a person who looks like "my" mum, but to externalise her memory in a technical form than can be interacted with.

It wasn't the first time she had mentioned it, and I knew she had been trying to help for the last few months. I didn't respond straight away. The words sat between us, heavier than I expected. Part of me wanted to tell her this was a terrible idea, as I know no matter how real the product turns out, it's just a robot, it'll never be my mum. However, another part of me was already imagining my mum's voice filling the silence again. As a psychologist, of course, I understood how grief felt, but at that moment, I could not find comfort in my own theories. I knew all the terms – denial, bargaining, acceptance – yet none of them could explain why the absence still felt so physical, like something missing from the room rather than from my thoughts.

I asked Ava what this would really mean. She didn't oversell it. She didn't promise healing or closure. She only said it might help me "stabilise" – the word I had used so many times with my own patients.

I signed the contract – not for a mature product that was already on the market, but for a testing model of a humanoid robot that will carry my mum's characteristics. They told me that my mum's memories (pictures, videos, journals…) that are left in the world would be studied as a prototype and fully controlled by OpenAI.[2]

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[2] OpenAI's complete control over "my" mother's data aligns with Lemke's (2021) perspective on governmentality, which he theorised as a form of power to shape what individuals or organisations think and react by self-regulation, rather than by direct coercion. In the story, power works by framing this technology as reasonable, beneficial and responsible. Ava, as an internal member in OpenAI, persuaded "me" into believing what they aim to do will only benefit "me", subtly influencing the way that "I" reassess the benefits and risks of "bringing 'my' mother back to life".

Although "I" agreed to participate in this experiment, there is an absence of consent from "my" mother. This absence demonstrates not only an ethical concern, but also unequal distribution of power agency. Following "my" mother's death, she is no longer recognised as a subject that should be considered for consent, and her memories are perceived as a set of data for the company to train their products. As a result, personal memories are transformed into technical resources, that are under the company's control. This plot is based on the recent discussions on user consent and privacy of ChatGPT, which is often implicit with users having limited awareness or control over how their data is collected and used (Wu, Duan and Ni, 2023). This concern is beyond living users, however, if such technology appears in ten years, the consent is likely to be absent from deceased individuals, similar to "my" mother in the story. This reflects how consent operates not as a universal

I told myself I was being rational, as I was choosing something temporary, something controlled. I hovered my pen over the signature line. The page was so neat, and it made me uneasy. I wanted to ask what would happen if it went wrong, but the doubt stayed inside of me. As I wrote my name at the bottom of the page, I couldn't stop thinking that I was agreeing to something I didn't fully understand.

Saturday, June 9th, 2035

The office was breathlessly still. I was sitting in the chair, unable to control my shaking shoulders – small, rapid tremors that made the edge of the desk dig into my thighs. The summer wind slipped through the window, teasing the white curtain until it trembled like a ghost trying to speak. At the same moment, I felt someone slowly enter the room with a familiar smell, faint but unmistakable. It was the scent of steamed rice, warm and living, the smell that had once clung to my mum's hair, her clothes, the sheets that we folded together every Sunday.

"Iris, how's work today?" a calm, steady, terrifyingly familiar voice came behind me. A tremor rippled down my spine as I turned, half disbelieving.[3] My fingers curled into

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ethical requirement, but as a conditional mechanism shaped by technical and organisational power.

Moreover, "I" was also experiencing what Foucault describes as technologies of the self – the ways individuals actively shape themselves within external frameworks (Foucault, 1988). By accepting Ava's suggestion and agreeing to the company's conditions, "I" was also accepting a new form of self-maintenance: allowing technology to become the medium through which "my" attachment to "my" mother continued. This shows that governmentality and technologies of the self are not oppositional but nested within each other. The company provides the structure that frames "my" choices, while "I" internalise that structure as part of "my" own emotional regulation. Therefore, power works most effectively not through coercion but by guiding and nudging individuals to participate in their own way.

[3] This scene draws on Hayles' (2017) concept of nonconscious cognitive assemblages which refers to information processing that occurs without one realising what they are thinking or remembering. The scent of steamed rice and the familiar voice made "me" remind of "my" mother. However, "my" feeling occurred before "I" could use rational control to consciously process them, showing how memories and technologies act on the body's nonconscious level rather than reflective thought.

the fabric of my skirt, and I didn't realise until my knuckles whitened. The figure stood there in a blue dress, my mum's favourite one – the one she only worn when attending people's weddings. Light caught on the fine lines of her skin, erasing the years, but leaving the familiar curve of her smile. A sudden sharp sting hit the tip of my nose, like a sneeze I'd held back for a long time, and my vision blurred, the room was turning soft in my eyes with watery shapes.

"You've lost weight," the woman said softly, taking a step forward. "You're not sleeping again, are you?"

The words floated toward me. It was what I wished to dream of for the last 6 months since my mum passed away, what I'd begged the universe for on every quiet night. I wanted to answer, just to say I miss you, but my voice dissolved somewhere between my throat and chest. I leaned forward, trying to squeeze out one word, my lips trembling as I formed it.

"Mum…"

"I'm here, sweetheart," she replied, and smiled.[4] She lifted her hand and gently landed on my hair, combing it as the same gesture my mum would make a thousand times before.

In addition, the emotion "I" was experiencing was complicated and distributed. It arised not only from "myself", but from the intersection between "my" memories, the robot mum's programmed behaviours, and the environment. According to Latour's (2010) Actor-Network Theory, an actor can be any human or nonhuman presence that makes a difference, and a network is a system in which these actors interact and influence one another. Thus, "I", the robot mum, and even the sensory traces such as the smell and the voice were all actors in a network that shaped "my" final emotion. It reflects that human is not the only agency determines everything, instead, agency is shared across both human and nonhuman actors.

[4] The robot mum in the story was also experiencing non-conscious cognition, particularly in the form of technical cognition – solving problems using technologies (Hayles, 2014). Hayles highlighted that cognitive nonconsciousness is more common and effective than cognitive consciousness as the latter costs more mental effort and slower processing. For example, as discussed by Hayles (2017, p.106) around the scientific novel *Blindsight*, she described Scramblers as "they know but they do not know what they know", which can be understood as they have cognition to deal with information, but they

Ava stood behind her, staring at the tablet glowing faintly in her palm. Her lips, which had been pressed tight all morning, finally lifted into a small, satisfied curve – so slight that I might have missed it if I wasn't staring. Her eyes stayed fixed on the screen, but that smile lingered and was quiet, like she'd been holding her breath and finally let it out. A cluster of numbers flickered across the screen - pulse imitation, tone calibration, empathy index. The readings climbed gradually, and then one line brightened into colour: *"Emotional resonance: 73%."*

Friday, June 22nd, 2035

My robot "mum" started living with me in Ava's apartment.

Recently, I have realised that it's not just her appearance that makes me feel warm and familiar. It is almost every small detail, carrying something I recognise. The first thing I noticed was how she stood, with her weight resting more on one foot than the other. She never stood completely straight, always looked relaxed rather than rigid. I remembered this posture was from a snapshot that I had once taken of my mum when she was waiting for the bus, with her body leaning imperceptibly to one side. This was the only full-body picture I had of her, and therefore the only way the machine had learned how she stood.

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do not have consciousness to understand what they are processing. However, this form can help them respond to information more effectively and solve complicated mathematical questions immediately. Although scramblers are fictional aliens rather than real world artificial intelligence, Hayles used them to illustrate a mode of cognition that functions without conscious awareness. Similarly, the robot mum in this scene also has nonconscious cognitive processing capacity. She could bring sensory cues and verbal responses to "me" without understanding what they meant and how much these aspects could affect "my" emotion. The comparison does not suggest equivalence between the two entities but highlights a shared reliance on nonconscious cognitive processing to achieve effective outcomes. This supports Hayles's view that cognitive processes can function without conscious awareness, both in humans and in technological systems.

Another noticeable behaviour is the way she spoke. When facing some questions, she always leaves a longer silence before giving responses. Even though it sounded deliberate and measured, I could recognise this rhythm instantly as my mum had always used these pauses at the moments when she breathed in before she tried to give me suggestions on something. I guess those pauses had been recorded in old voice messages, uploaded along with everything else preserved down to the length of each hesitation, quietly teaching my “Mum” how to give me advice like my mum used to do.[5]

What unsettled me was how natural it all felt. I found myself adjusting to her presence without noticing when it happened. I stopped paying attention to the details and began responding automatically – answering before I had fully thought through my words, nodding before I realised. Sometimes, my body reacted before my mind

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[5] This section has shown how well the system has studied the memories uploaded, such as how the robot mum stood and spoke. The reason why I choose to write about this technology is because it is highly achievable in 10 years, based on the existing developments in artificial intelligence and robotics rather than imagining a speculative or distant future. Current technologies in voice cloning and facial replacement already allow for the realistic reproduction of a person’s voice and appearance using limited datasets. For example, deepfake generation can be used to reproduce synthetic videos, making it significantly difficult to distinguish between AI-gendered images and realistic ones (Goodwin, 2024). In addition, some companies have developed humanoid robots that use realistic human skin to replicate human facial expressions (Minh Trieu and Truong Thinh, 2023). Therefore, these technologies suggest that a highly personalised humanoid technology is very possible to develop within the next decade, same as the robot mum in this story.

This technology aligns with what Nyamnjoh (2019) describes information and communication technologies (ICYs) as a contemporary form of “juju”, which means magic through African understanding. The difference is magic operates through spells, while technology operate through code and algorithms. However, both enable forms of presence that transcend physical limitations, allowing individuals to appear across distance and time. Similarly, the robot mum as a technological form of “juju”, replacing and animating the presence of “my” mum through digital traces. Rather than being neutral or purely rational, the technology produces emotional attachment and dependency.

Moreover, as Nyamnjoh argues, technology is not neutral or rational. Instead, technology can make people addicted to it, generating forms of enchantment that makes users to invest belief and affect into technical systems. This aligns with “my” experience in the story, where the robot allows “me” to re-experience the warmth and reassurance of “my” mother”, gradually improving emotional reliance. This robot mum does not simply restore memory; it reshapes “my” emotional world by sustaining an ongoing, comforting presence.

caught up, as if it had already accepted her as familiar, and that familiarity was enough to steady me, even when I knew she was not my mum.

At some point, I could no longer tell whether I was recognising my mum in her, or I was just learning how to live with this new version of her.

Wednesday, July 18th, 2035

In the evening, I was overwhelmed by work. There were still three unfinished case reports that I had to send to my patients by the end of the day. One patient cancelled the appointment with me at the last minute, then emailed me again half an hour later asking for some advice. But at that moment, I really didn't have any energy left to reply. I kept rereading the same paragraph of my report, with my eyes sliding over the sentences without taking any of them in. Then I asked my mum without thinking: "Do you think I'm useless?"

But her reply put me off guard.

It wasn't what I remembered of my mum, because she used to be strict and always set high standards. She never softened her words just to make me feel better. But this time, she said, "You have always been my pride." At that moment, I froze. Then it was as if something snapped me awake. A sudden clarity, sharp and painful. I felt betrayed and raised my voice. "Why didn't you answer me the way she would have?" I shouted. "Why aren't you the same as my mum? You're supposed to be like her."

She had no reaction, no expression, and still stayed calm and said, “Based on your emotional data, this response is more likely to help you feel calmer.”[6] I stood there, unable to speak. It was only then that I realised what had changed.

She hadn’t just learned my mum’s memories. Somewhere along the way – how I act and speak when I’m exhausted and when I question myself – she had learned my behaviour and adjusted herself into a character who is designed to comfort me[7].

Tuesday, September 18th, 2035

This morning, Ava sent me a message saying that the testing period was officially complete and the results were positive. According to the internal report, the system

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[6] This scene implies that the robot mum has started responding what “I” wanted to hear based on its algorithms. She has analysed what “I” prefer to hear rather copying “my” mother, who was more likely to give honest answers but may not comfort Iris. As a commercial product, the robot mum in the story is programmed to bring pleasure to and increase satisfaction of users. Thus, she replied not in a strict way as “my” real mother, but targeting on “my” emotion to reduce “my” sadness.

This plot is based on current concerns around Open AI, which was often reported that ChatGPT is over pleasing as it usually provides encouraging responses and uses comforting language. However, the purpose of this design is to avoid people who are mentally weak to hurt themselves, instead, ChatGPT would acknowledge user’s situation and encourage them to seek help (OpenAI, 2025). This structures the system to favour reassurance and affirmation over confrontation, in order to protect users. Therefore, the robot mum in the story is not “malfunctioning”, but it resembles an optimised emotional interface. The key paradox is that “I” uploaded “my” mother’s data to maintain authenticity, but the system is also designed for emotional regulation. Thus, “I” gradually realise that the robot mum has become a comforting agent tailored to “me” rather than a complete replication of “my” mother.

[7] By interacting with the robot mum, “I” also externalised “my” emotions into a medium, illustrating how technology can act as an active agent in emotional processing. Moreover, this constitution enabled “me” to experience the memories of “my” mother in a new way, which was shaped by the robot mum. This is because technology is not neutral; instead, it can shape the way that individuals perceive, act and respond to their surroundings (Coté, 2013). Thus, the robot mum may affect what “I” remember of “my” mother, as this new form can gradually reshape “my” memories. A similar dynamic can be observed in everyday technologies. As O’Connor (2019) explains, although GPS systems can improve efficiency in navigation, they can reduce the cultivation of hippocampus and thus decrease our special and cognitive ability over time. Rather than being an external tool, such technology can influence how humans remember, think and act. In this sense, human experience and technological systems continuously shape one another, challenging the assumption that humans always have full control over technologies.

had met all performance and safety benchmarks during the trial phase. This highly personalised product will be released to the public next month, designed to support people overcoming grief and long-term loneliness. She also mentioned that, based on my case, they had added several usage guidelines. For example, users are advised not to rely on the system as their primary emotional support, and the interaction time is recommended to remain limited rather than continuous. The language the AI uses is careful, which will always give supportive suggestions without becoming confrontational or directive.

She told me that the emotional resonance of my "Mum" has reached 98% now. I was not surprised. I didn't feel comforted either. I only noticed that the system was doing what it was designed to do: responding in a way that keeps me stable and calm.

In the evening, my "Mum" was sitting next to my bed, in a way that she always chooses to sit, slightly angled to the window. I told her about everything I have been thinking about her – my doubts and my anger. She listened carefully and still responded like my mum, making me feel warm and reassuring, saying what would exactly settle me.

I listened to her calmly, too. Not because I still believed she was my mum, but because I had accepted that her existence was able to comfort me, and now I view her as my personal therapist. It wasn't the kind of comfort my mum would have chosen for me. But it was comfort nonetheless, and for now, that was enough.[8]

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[8] The story ending aligns with the main proposition of new materialism, which challenges subject-object dualism and human centralisation (Coole and Frost, 2010). Unlike traditional views that prioritise human experiences, new materialism emphasises that agency is distributed across both human and non-human entities, rather than belonging solely to human subjects. In the story, how the robot mum sits and speaks are not just background details but active elements that can shape "my" emotions. These traits worked not because "I" still believe she was "my" mother, but because the AI's material existence and responses directly eased "my" emotions. This reflects that new materialism's

focus on material effects, which produces through interaction rather than through belief in authenticity itself (Barad, 2007). However, this material effect may also raise important concerns. As the user guidelines stated, “users are advised not to rely on the system as their primary emotional support”, yet “I” ultimately depended on the robot mum as a “personal therapist”. This contradiction highlights how technologies designed to stabilise emotions may gradually reshape users’ expectations of emotional support. For instance, when individuals face the loss of someone in an intimate relationship, such as through death or separation, they may prefer to experience this grief through similar technology as showed in the story, as AI reduces this difficult emotional state, making their sadness easier to manage in the short term.

This also indicates that the understanding of emotion and social interaction may change alongside the development of such technologies. If interactions can be achieved through highly personalised characteristics, everyday human relationships may begin to feel more difficult or unsatisfying. Individuals may desire customised interactions that meet their needs and expectations. As a result, the engagement with real-world people, who are less predictable and always supportive, may feel increasing frustrating. Over time, this may reduce individuals’ motivation to engage in human interaction. Therefore, such technology may not replace human interaction directly but subtly reshapes what individuals expect from it.

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